

Ringtail

Bassariscus astutus

- ↔ 12–17 in (30–43 cm)
- 📍 C. and W. US to S. Mexico
- ⊗ Common

This slim, agile North American hunter is a relative of the raccoons and has a similar black-and-white ringed tail. Otherwise mainly brown, it has big eyes surrounded by black rings and striking white eyebrows. It hunts at night for small mammals, birds, and reptiles, but it has a broad diet and also forages for insect grubs, fruit, and nuts.

Crab-eating raccoon

Procyon cancrivorus

- ↔ 18–35 in (45–90 cm)
- 📍 Central America to C. South America
- ⊗ Common

Similar to the common raccoon, with a ringed tail and black-masked eyes, this crab-eater lives up to its name by hunting crabs along seashores and the edges of rivers and marshes. It feels for prey in the shallows with its sensitive, nimble front paws. Solitary and nocturnal, it retreats to a tree hole by day.

Stoat

Mustela erminea

- ↔ 7–10 in (18–25 cm)
- 📍 North America, Greenland, Europe to N. and E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The long, slender, flexible body of this widespread predator is well adapted for pursuing other small mammals, such as voles, through



their burrows. It also kills rabbits, even though they often far outweigh it. It is red-brown above and creamy white below, but in the snowy north of its range, it molts to pure white in winter, aside from the tip of the tail, which is always black; this white form is known as an ermine.

Least weasel

Mustela nivalis

- ↔ 7–10 in (18–25 cm)
- 📍 North America, Europe to N., C., and E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Similar to a stoat, but with an even smaller, slimmer, brown and white body and tiny head, the least weasel can enter the smallest mouse or vole burrow in search of prey. It specializes in hunting these small rodents, which are so abundant and widespread that the least weasel consequently has a huge range across both North America and northern Eurasia. In the far north, it turns white in winter for camouflage in the snow—this is for its own protection as well as to conceal it from potential prey. It lives alone, using several nests in crevices or old burrows.



European polecat

Mustela putorius

- ↔ 14–20 in (35–51 cm)
- 📍 Europe
- ⊗ Common

This relatively large member of the weasel family has long dark outer fur with creamy-yellow underfur visible as it moves and a black mask across its eyes. Its sinuous body and short legs allow it to enter rabbit holes in search of prey. A domesticated form of the polecat—the ferret—is used by hunters to flush rabbits out of their burrows. It also runs and swims well. If threatened, it defends itself with a foul-smelling

sinuous body



product of its anal glands. Male and female polecats defend separate territories, but the males' territories usually overlap those of the females.

American mink

Neovison vison

- ↔ 12–22 in (30–56 cm)
- 📍 North America; introduced to Europe
- ⊗ Common

Native to North America, this adaptable relative of the weasels has become widespread across Eurasia as a result of escapes from

fur farms. Normally dark brown to almost black, it resembles a smaller, darker otter, and often uses its partly webbed feet to hunt in the water for frogs, fish, and water voles. An excellent swimmer, it can stay submerged for distances of up to 98 ft (30 m). It also takes a wide variety of prey on land and is widely seen as a threat to native wildlife in its introduced range.

dark, glossy fur



Fisher

Martes pennanti

- ↔ 19–30 in (48–76 cm)
- 📍 Canada to N. US
- ⊗ Common

The cat-sized fisher is the biggest of the martens—a long, low-slung forest predator with dense, dark brown fur and a bushy tail. It usually hunts on the ground for other mammals, including porcupines, which it kills by repeatedly biting at their unprotected faces. It can climb well and often makes its den high in a hollow tree, where it also raises its young.

Sable

Martes zibellina

- ↔ 13–18 in (33–46 cm)
- 📍 N. and E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

This is the northeast Asian equivalent of the fisher, famous for its dense, brown-black fur, which made it a prime target for fur-trappers over several centuries. Fast and agile, it hunts in the forests for small mammals such as hares and rodents, scavenges from the kills of wolves, and also eats fruit. It often adopts an abandoned burrow as a breeding nest, but makes temporary dens for shelter from the cold when foraging for food in winter.